

One answer is: Yes.

Physical properties can
cause phenomenal
properties, **and**

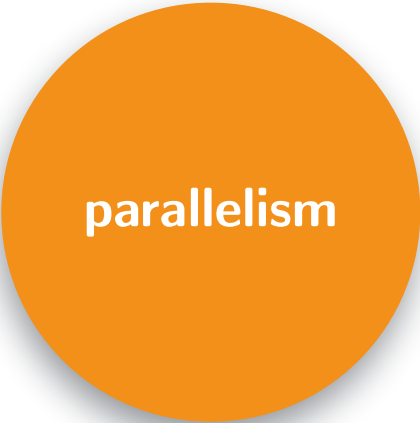
phenomenal properties can
cause physical properties.

A second answer is: Yes.

Physical properties can
cause phenomenal
properties; **but** phenomenal
properties cannot cause
physical properties.

A large, solid red circle is centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the word "interactionism" is written in a bold, white, sans-serif font, centered horizontally and vertically.

interactionism

A large, solid orange circle serves as the background for the text.

parallelism



**epi-
phenomenalism**

ANN'S BLOOD SUGAR
FALLS BELOW 80
MG/DL

ANN FEELS HUNGER,
AND DECIDES TO
WALK TO THE
FRIDGE.

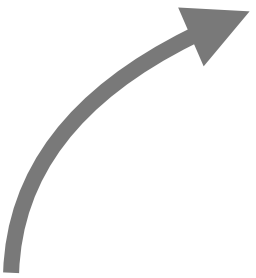
ANN WALKS TO THE
FRIDGE AND OPENS
THE DOOR

ANN HAS A VISUAL
SENSATION OF AN
APPLE AND DECIDES TO
EAT IT.

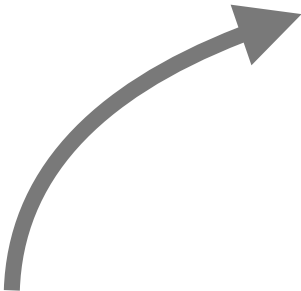
ANN REACHES OUT FOR THE
APPLE AND BRINGS IT TO
HER MOUTH AND TAKES A
BITE.

ANN TASTES THE APPLE
AND FEELS LESS
HUNGRY .











This might push one towards the initially surprising epiphenomenalist position. Unlike the parallelist, the epiphenomenalist does not think of the physical and mental realms as entirely disconnected. And unlike the interactionist, the epiphenomenalist does not have to think that physics must be supplemented with an additional mental 'force.'

ANN FEELS HUNGER,
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But peripheralism leads to a puzzle.

Suppose that I ask you how you are feeling, and you say 'I am feeling cold.' The event of you saying that is a physical event. It is a report of one of your phenomenal properties. Since (according to the epiphenomenalist) phenomenal properties never cause physical events, your utterance of 'I am cold' was not caused (even indirectly) by your feeling cold.

But that is deeply weird. Ordinarily when we report on things we do so on the basis of a causal interaction with them. If we try to describe things with which we have no causal contact it seems like we can only describe them correctly by being lucky. So it seems like we can only correctly describe our own conscious states by luck. But that seems crazy.

The puzzle is, in a weird way, the reverse of the puzzle we discussed for the parallelist. The parallelist holds that the physical world is entirely causally separate from the mental world. That raised the question: why believe in a physical world at all?

The epiphenomenalist holds that the phenomenal world has no causal influence on our reports about our own consciousness. This raises the question: why believe in consciousness at all? We would, after all, be saying just the same thing things about our conscious experience even if we were not conscious at all.



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properties, and

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causaphenomenal

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properties; but phenomena

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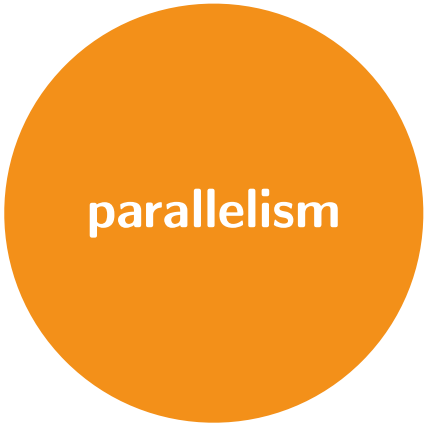
causal phenomena

properties cannot cause

Physical properties can



interactionism

A large, solid orange circle serves as the background for the entire image.

parallelism

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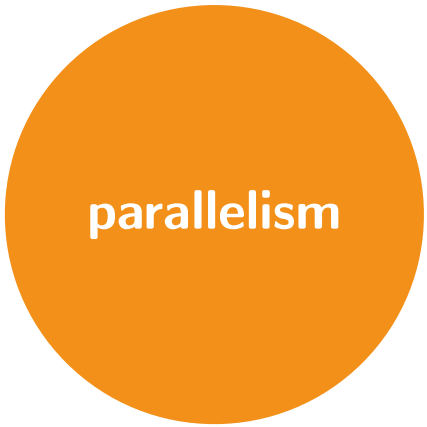
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interactionism

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parallelism



epi-

phenomenalism